The 5 things Gold Coast customers check before they call you

And what they do when they can't find them

Studio Velox · Gold Coast · Oct 22, 2026

Nobody is comparing you. They are ruling you out.

Your customer is not weighing you up against the competition. They are looking for a reason to cross you off, and then they are ringing whoever is left.

Think about the last time you needed a tradie you had never used. The hot water went out, or a tap would not stop. You did not research anyone. You searched, you glanced at what came back, and you skipped past anything that looked like hard work.

Your customers do that to you.

The awkward part is that being ruled out feels like nothing from your end. Someone who crosses you off never rings, never emails, and never tells you why. You do not lose the job. You never hear that the job existed.

That is what this report is about. Five things a Gold Coast customer checks before they pick up the phone, in roughly the order they check them, and what they actually do at each point if they cannot find an answer.

None of it requires you to understand marketing. All of it is things you can see for yourself in about ten minutes.

Check 1: Can they find you at all

They are not searching your business name. They do not know your business name. They search what they need and where they are: plumber burleigh, mobile mechanic southport, physio robina.

On a phone, what comes back first is a small map with a handful of businesses pinned on it. Those listings get the attention, because they are at the top and they carry a Call button. Below them sit the ordinary blue links, which most people never scroll to.

Being on that map is free. It is a Google Business Profile, and you can have one without having a website at all. If you do not have one, this is the cheapest thing you will ever fix.

But the listing has a Website button on it, and that is where the next tap goes. Three things usually happen when someone taps it:

- **Nothing is there.** The button is missing. The customer has no way to find out anything more about you than your name and a star rating.
- **It goes to a Facebook page.** They see your last post, which may be from two years ago, and a wall of other people's comments. A quiet Facebook page reads as a business that has wound down.
- **A website loads, badly.** Text too small to read, a menu that will not open, a phone number that is an image instead of a link. They pinch and zoom twice, then give up.

Do this yourself

Search what you do plus your suburb on a phone that is not yours, and not signed in to your own Google account. Your own phone will not tell you the truth, because Google shapes results around what you have searched and visited before. Your own business always looks easy to find from your own phone.

Borrow someone else's. Look at what they see.

Check 2: Has anyone else used you, and did it go well

The star rating is the first filter, but it is not the one that decides. What a customer is really working out is whether this has gone well before, for someone with a job like theirs.

A perfect 5.0 from three reviews is weaker than a 4.6 from eighty. Three reviews looks like your mates. Eighty looks like a business that has been turning up for years. And a 4.6 with one bad review you have replied to politely is stronger than a flawless record, because it proves the reviews are real.

Then they want to see the work. This is the gap that hurts most, because a star rating tells them you are competent and shows them nothing.

Photos of your own jobs beat everything else you could write

Most people quietly assume written testimonials were written by the business. You cannot prove a sentence. You can prove a photo.

For a trade or anything physical, before and after shots of your own work are the single most persuasive thing you can put in front of a customer, and they cost you nothing but the thirty seconds it takes to photograph a job you have just finished.

Take them on your phone as you go. Badly lit and real beats a stock photo of someone else's kitchen, every time. A customer can tell the difference instantly, and a stock photo makes them wonder what you are hiding.

Do this yourself

Open your Google listing and count the photos that show work you actually did. If the answer is none, start taking them this week.

Check 3: What is this going to cost me

This is the question everyone has and almost nobody answers. Silence does not read as neutral. Silence reads as expensive.

Nobody expects a fixed price for a job you have not seen yet. What they want to know is whether they are in forty-dollar territory or four-hundred-dollar territory, so they know whether to keep reading or go and ask someone else.

When there is no number anywhere, two thoughts arrive. The first is that you must be at the dear end. The second, and worse, is that the price will depend on what you think they can afford. Plenty of people have had that experience with a tradie and they are wary of it.

A range beats a number, and a number beats nothing

The objection is always the same, and it is fair: every job is different. That is exactly why a range works better than a price.

- A callout fee. "$95 to come out and look, and that comes off the job if you go ahead."
- A from-price. "Most blocked drains land between $180 and $350. What moves it is whether we need the camera."
- One real job, with its real number. "Last month: new hot water system at Mermaid Waters, supplied and fitted, $2,180."

That last one does more work than a page of explanation, because it is specific and it is checkable-sounding. It gives the customer a shape to compare against.

One warning. An hourly rate is the weakest number you can publish, because it tells the customer nothing about what they will actually pay. "$120 an hour" could mean ninety dollars or nine hundred. A from-price or a fixed figure answers the question. An hourly rate just moves it.

Do this yourself

Pick the three jobs you do most often. Write down what each one typically costs and what makes it go up. That is your pricing page, and it took you five minutes.

Check 4: Are you a real business that will actually turn up

Underneath everything else, this is the worry. Not that you will do a bad job. That you will not come, or you will take a deposit and go quiet, or something will go wrong and there will be nobody to chase.

A customer cannot verify any of that in thirty seconds. So they look for small signals instead, and they take the absence of those signals as an answer.

The signals, cheapest first

- **A face and a name.** One photo of the person who will knock on the door. This is the biggest one and it is free. A business with no human on it anywhere feels like a middleman at best.
- **Your ABN, written on the page.** Nearly every business has one and almost nobody displays it. Anyone can check it in seconds on ABN Lookup, which is exactly why showing it signals that you have nothing to hide.
- **Your licence number**, whichever applies to your trade. Quoting the number does more than the word "licensed", because a number can be looked up and a word cannot.
- **Where you work.** "Servicing the Gold Coast from Coomera to Coolangatta" tells someone in Palm Beach that you will come. A business with no location at all reads as a call centre.
- **Insurance, if you carry it.** Say so plainly and say what kind.

None of these take a designer. They are facts you already have, written down where a stranger can read them.

Do this yourself

Open whatever you have online now and ask one question: could a stranger work out who I am, where I work, and that I am a registered business? If any of the three is missing, that is the first thing to fix.

Check 5: Will you actually answer

The last check is the most practical one. The customer has decided you might do. Now they want to know whether contacting you will lead anywhere.

Your hours have to be right

Google shows "Open now" or "Closed" on your listing. If your hours are wrong, or missing, you lose the after-hours calls, and the after-hours calls are the urgent ones that nobody shops around on.

If you take calls until seven, say until seven. If you do emergencies, say so in those words, because that is the word people type.

Not everyone will ring you

This is the one most owners underestimate. A large share of people, and nearly everyone under about forty, will not phone a business they have never dealt with. They will text, or fill in a form, or send a message and wait.

If a phone number is your only way in, those people do not call you and ask for another option. They go to the business that offered one.

The fix is small: a text number, a short form, or a message button. Two fields, not ten. Name and what they need.

But then you have to answer it

An unanswered form is worse than no form, because now you have wasted their time as well as lost the job. If you cannot check it daily, do not put it up.

Same with missed calls. You are under a house or up a ladder and the phone rings out, which is normal and nobody holds it against you. What loses the job is silence afterwards. A voicemail that says when you will ring back, or a quick text saying "on a job, call you at four", keeps the job alive.

Do this yourself

Ring your own business number from a phone the customer would use, and let it go to voicemail. Listen to what they hear. Then try to contact yourself without ringing, and see whether it is possible.

So what do they do when they cannot find it

They go to the next one. That is the whole answer.

They do not ring you to ask what you charge. They do not think "I will check their Facebook later". They do not save your name for next time. They tap back, and the next business on the list gets the call.

Here is the part that should annoy you. The business that got the job is usually not better than you. Not more skilled, not cheaper, not more honest. They answered the five questions above and you did not, and that was the entire contest.

And you will never find out. There is no notification for a customer who ruled you out. The only symptom is a phone that is quieter than it should be for someone who does work this good, and that symptom looks exactly like a slow month.

Then it compounds, because the customer who used the other bloke is the one who recommends him at the barbecue. You do not get recommended for a job you never got.

If you only do one thing this week

In order. The first five are free and none of them need a web designer.

1. **Claim your Google Business Profile and get the details right.** Twenty minutes. Correct hours, the number you actually answer, your service area, and the category a customer would search for rather than the one that sounds most impressive.
2. **Put ten photos of your own work on it.** Taken on your phone, on jobs you have already done. Do this before anything that costs money.
3. **Write down the prices of your three most common jobs.** A range and what moves it. You will use these numbers for the next ten years.
4. **Ask your last five happy customers for a Google review.** Text them the link. Most people say yes and simply have never been asked.
5. **Add one way to reach you that is not a phone call.** A text number is enough. Then answer it.

Notice that none of that is a website. If you do those five things you will be ahead of most of your competitors on the Gold Coast, and it will have cost you an afternoon.

The reason to have a website after that is simple. Everything above lives on somebody else's platform, arranged the way they want it, next to ads for your competitors. A website is the one place where all five answers sit together, in your order, with nothing else on the page competing for the customer you just worked so hard to attract.

Do the free things first. Then build the place they point to.

Who wrote this

I am Phil Campbell. I build websites for Gold Coast businesses, on my own, under the name Studio Velox.

I wrote this because I spend a lot of time looking at local businesses that do good work and are invisible to the people trying to find them. Almost none of it is the owner's fault. Nobody tells you any of the above when you start a business.

If you want to do the five things in the last section yourself, please do. You do not need me for any of them, and you will be better off for it.

If you would rather it was handled, that is what I do. I build you a one-page site for nothing, up front, before you have paid me anything. If you like it, it is $47 a month to host it and look after it, and you get fourteen days after it goes live to make up your mind. Say no in that time and you pay nothing.

There is no minimum term and no exit fee either. Once you are past the fourteen days you can stop whenever you like. The month you have already paid for is the end of it, and the site stays yours.

One page is not the only option. If one page cannot carry the whole story:

- **Five-page website.** $497 to build, then $97 a month. Includes email on your own business name rather than a Gmail address.
- **Five pages plus the assistant.** $997 to build, then $147 a month. The assistant answers your customers' questions on the page at any hour, and tells you afterwards what they asked.
- **Anything bigger.** A shop, a booking system, more pages, whatever it is. One price for the whole job, agreed before I start. It does not move, and there is no meter running while I work.

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If you would like, send me your business name and I will have a look at what a customer sees when they search for you, and tell you what I would fix first. No charge and no obligation to do anything about it.